Lodestar: an explainable cognitive growth agent

AI4Brain, CISTAC 1.0 — technical report

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Abstract

Lodestar is an AI agent that assesses sixteen cognitive skills through short games, keeps a dynamic, historised profile of each person (the *Brain Twin*) in which every estimate carries an 80% range, coaches in natural language with every number traced to a cited fact, and adapts exercises, goals and plans as the profile changes. A LangGraph agent with 22 nodes decides what to do next and records every decision with the options it weighed. A Kalman-Elo scoring engine turns answers into estimates with honest uncertainty; four learned or statistical models forecast growth, detect drifting engagement, find the fatigue point and pick the game that helps most. On 200 simulated people with known skills, the profile recovers the true skill with correlation 0.82 after three sessions and 0.91 after ten, and its 80% ranges contain the truth 79.9% of the time. The system runs without camera or microphone, without a cloud model, and degrades gracefully when its models or memory are down. Lodestar is a practice coach; it never assesses medical or psychological conditions.

1 Objectives and scope

The brief asks for an agent that *assesses* the user across cognitive dimensions non-clinically, *understands* performance as an uncertainty-aware percentage profile, *coaches* with explainable, personalised feedback, and *improves* through adaptive exercises and measurable learning paths (Layers A–C), with an AI Collaboration Score, documented ethics, and optional voice, emotion-aware and predictive features. Table 1 maps each requirement to the component that meets it. All three bonus features are implemented.

Requirement	Lodestar
A: tasks per dimension; score, RT, errors, behaviour	43 browser games over 16 skills; every trial stores correctness, response time, hint level, practice flag and optional confidence
A: each dimension documented	Generated skill pages: definition, tasks, scoring, uncertainty, biases and evidence level
A: non-biometric mode mandatory	The default; camera and voice tone are off, per-switch consented, and never write to the profile
Brain Twin: history; projections with uncertainty	Append-only event log, daily history, growth forecast as an 80% range
B: explainable coaching, no clinical terms	Facts packet → draft → verify → repair; citations on every number; banned-word check in lint and at runtime
C: adaptation, plans, radar, curves, heatmaps, goals	Difficulty targeting, bandit, goals, personal experiments; all four chart types with ranges
AI Collaboration Score (0–100, formula)	Five components measured in play; Bayesian shares; documented weights and sensitivity
Ethics & data	Layered consent, export, deletion with receipt, retention job, encrypted user keys
Bonus	Voice in/out with wake word; on-device strain cues; predictive growth

Table 1: Brief requirements and where they are met.

2 Architecture

Why this architecture. A graph agent (LangGraph 1.2) rather than a free-form tool loop makes every step inspectable and resumable: state is checkpointed in Postgres, so a browser crash in the middle of a game resumes on the same trial. Deterministic code decides *what* to do (which skill, which game, which difficulty) and records the decision with its candidates and the parts of each score; the language model only decides *how to say it*, from a facts packet. This split keeps decisions explainable and testable, keeps every number traceable, and lets the app run with a small local model or none at all. Users bring their own key for eight hosted providers, or use a

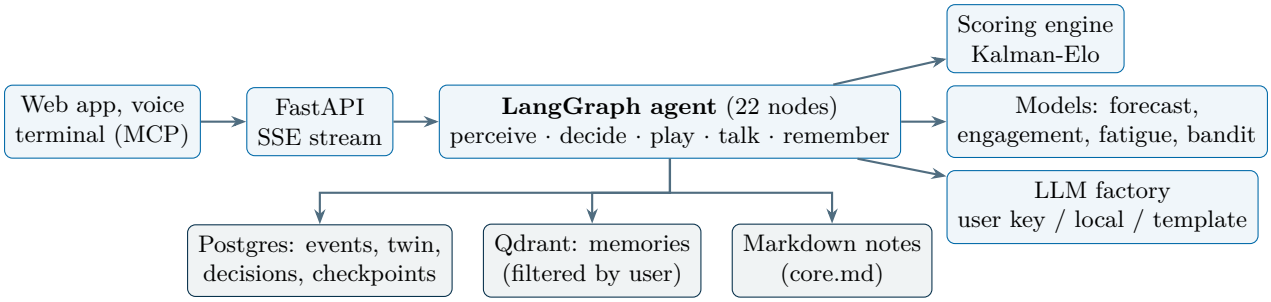


Figure 1: System overview. Postgres is the system of record; Qdrant holds searchable memories; Markdown holds the notes Lodestar writes.

local Ollama model; keys are encrypted at rest and decrypted only inside the LLM factory. All storage is Postgres (structured data, append-only events), Qdrant (memory search, always filtered by user) and readable Markdown notes.

3 Assessment and the Brain Twin

Skills and tasks. Sixteen skills are grouped into attention, self-control, memory, speed, reasoning and language, each tagged *established*, *moderate* or *experimental* by the strength of its evidence. Classic paradigms (flanker, Stroop, n-back, Corsi, go/no-go, task switching, digit span, mental rotation, Tower of London, matrices) are rebuilt from their published descriptions, alongside original games and a Detective story whose chapters are games. A registry in YAML describes every game (skills and loadings, scoring, difficulty knobs, practice trials) and drives the UI, the scorer and the agent alike. A five-minute warm-up battery measures the core skills first.

Scoring. Each skill d has a belief $\theta_d \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$ on a logit scale, each level a difficulty b. For an answer with outcome S (timed tasks use a high-speed high-stakes rule: right *and* within the reference pace),

$$p = \text{logistic}\Big(\tfrac{\mu - b}{\sqrt{1+\pi\sigma^2/8}}\Big), \qquad w = \text{loading} \times \text{reliability} \times \text{trust},$$

$$\sigma'^2 = \big(1/\sigma^2 + w\,p(1-p)\big)^{-1}, \qquad \mu' = \mu + \sigma'^2\, w\,(S - p).$$

Uncertainty grows with time away ($\sigma^2 \leftarrow \min(\sigma_0^2, \sigma^2 + q\,\Delta t)$) and with within-session process noise; a practice prior fitted to 1.08 million Lumosity learning curves moves μ by the expected gain per round. Cold-start priors come from skill correlations computed on 180,000 NCPT test runs. Estimates are shown as percentiles with 80% ranges ($\mu \pm 1.28\sigma$), labelled "simulated norms" until a linking study maps our scale onto published norms. Rounds that look like bad data (too fast, flat responding, outliers) are flagged and down-weighted rather than trusted.

History. A scored round is one transaction: events, trials, round, profile and daily history, under a per-user advisory lock. Events are never updated, so the whole profile can be rebuilt from the log. The Brain Twin shows each skill as a card (estimate, range bar, a shadow that widens with uncertainty), wired to skills of the same family and to the skills it correlates with most.

4 The AI coach and explainability

Each reply is built in three steps. The agent assembles a *facts packet* (numbered facts, decisions, knowledge tips and memories, each with an id); the LLM drafts in the chosen voice (Willow, Spark, Sage or Buddy); a verifier rejects any number not found in a cited fact, any banned clinical word and any unsupported claim, asks for a repair, and falls back to a template if the repair fails. In the UI every cited number shows its chip (`[F2]`), and "Why?" opens the decision behind a game: the candidate skills, the score of each, and its parts (uncertainty, staleness, goal weight, bandit gain, fatigue, repetition). The Agent page shows the five stages lighting up live and every decision with the options it weighed; the full trace is stored per session. With the local `qwen3.5:4b` model, 1 of 4 first drafts passed verification, 3 after repair and 1 by template: 4 of 4 final replies were faithful, which is the point of the loop.

5 Adaptive learning and the dashboard

Difficulty targets the success rate the user chose (Chill, Balanced or Push): $b_{\text{next}} = \mu - \text{logit}(p^*)$, with an in-game staircase. On the simulator, Balanced mode achieved 77.7% success against an 80% target. **What to**

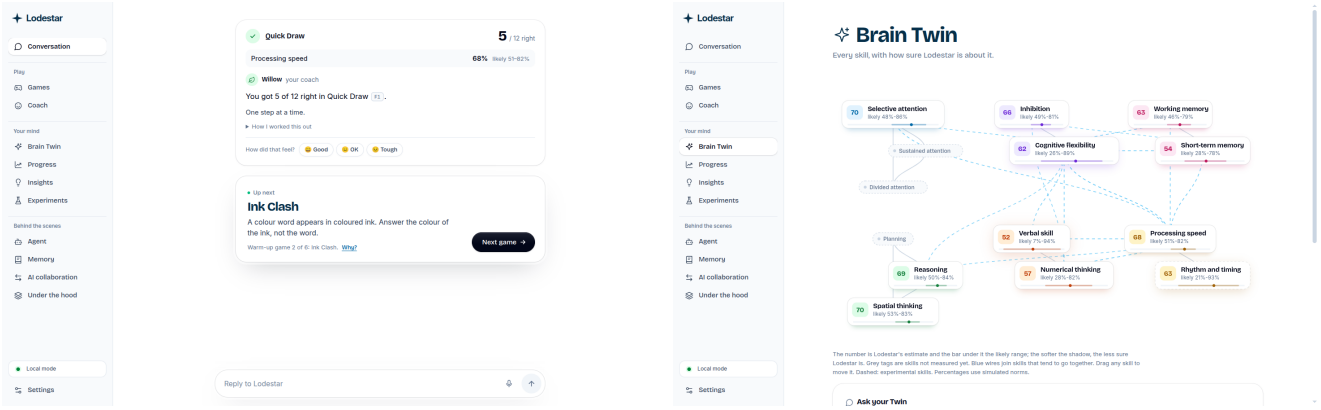


Figure 2: Left: after a game, the score, the skill it moved with its range, and the coach with a cited fact. Right: the Brain Twin, each skill a card with its estimate and range.

play is chosen by a weighted score over skills (uncertainty, staleness, goals, experiments, fatigue, repetition) plus a Thompson-sampling bandit that learns which game moves each skill most for this person (+0.12 to +0.24 true-skill gain over random games, 95% interval). **Plans evolve**: goals are stated as "know this skill to within $\pm N$ points by a date", with rounds left estimated from the update rule; personal experiments compare morning and evening sessions and report a verdict only when $P(\text{one is better}) \geq 0.8$. The dashboard has the radar, progress curves with forecast bands and life-context strips, heatmaps by week and time of day, and goal cards; every estimate shows its range.

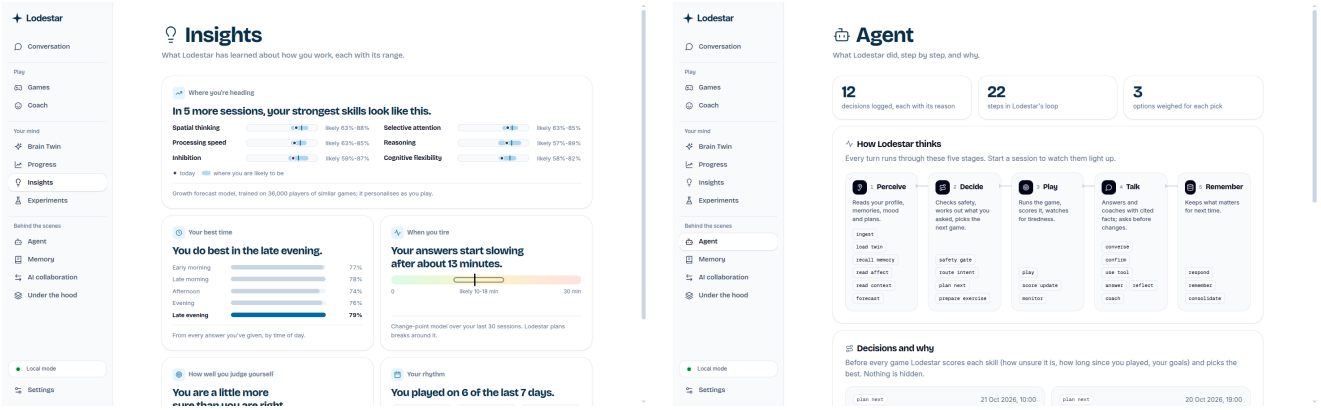


Figure 3: Left: Insights, each reading with its range and the model behind it. Right: the Agent page, the five stages and the decisions with their reasons.

6 AI Collaboration Score

Each of five components is measured inside games: critical verification (finding planted mistakes in the AI's worked solutions, with consent), autonomy (solving before asking for a hint), iteration (a better retry after a failure), clarification (asking before acting on an ambiguous instruction) and responsible use (taking a suggested break). With a Beta(2,2) prior per component,

$$s_k = \frac{\text{successes}_k + 2}{\text{opportunities}_k + 4}, \qquad \text{ACS} = 100 \sum_k w_k s_k,$$

and an 80% range from 1,000 Monte Carlo draws. Weights are V 0.30, A 0.20, I 0.20, C 0.15, R 0.15: verification is raised from the brief's 0.25 because over-reliance is the main failure mode of AI assistance, clarification lowered because its opportunities are rarest. Ranks are stable under ±5-point weight changes (worst Spearman 0.997 on 200 simulated people).

7 Predictive models

- **Growth forecast.** LightGBM quantile models (10/50/90) with split-conformal calibration, trained on 36,297 users of Steyvers & Schafer's open Lumosity data and evaluated on held-out *users*: observed 80% interval

coverage 79.6–80.0% for horizons of 1 to 20 sessions. In the app a person's own history outweighs the population forecast as data accumulate.

- **Engagement risk.** Logistic regression on eight behaviour features, trained on OULAD (25,273 students); held-out AUC 0.857 (LightGBM 0.863, days-since-last rule 0.828) with an inductive Venn–Abers range (ECE 0.006). It only ever triggers a shorter, easier session; the score is never shown.
- **Fatigue point.** A change-point detector on standardised log response times per session, combined with a Kaplan–Meier curve across sessions, gives the minute at which answers start slowing (median with its middle half). Sessions where the person slowed but became more accurate are excluded.
- **Best next game.** The Thompson-sampling bandit above, updated from every round.

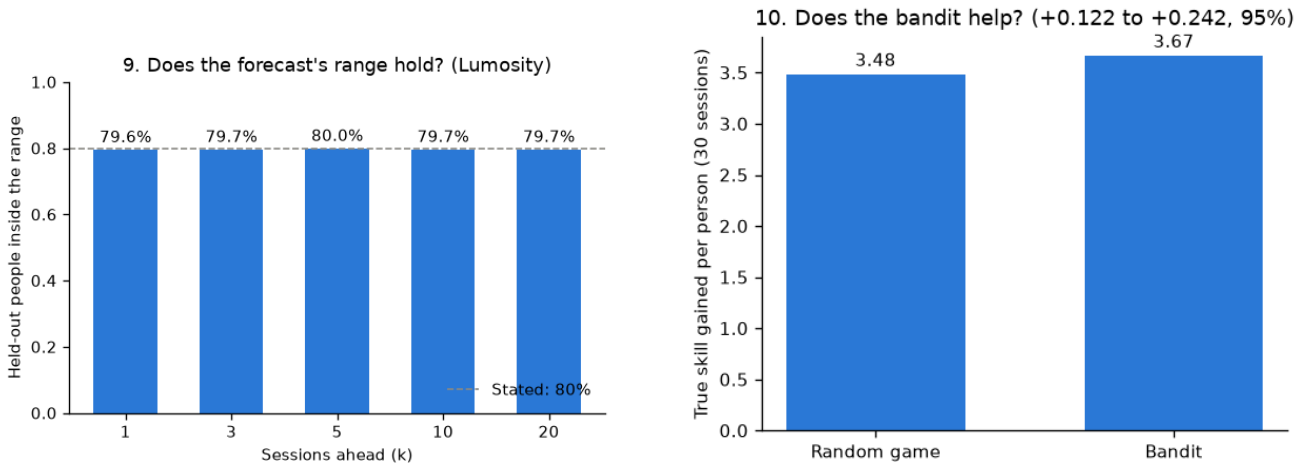


Figure 4: Left: the growth forecast's 80% ranges hold on held-out real players at every horizon. Right: true-skill gain with the bandit versus random games.

8 Evaluation

A simulator draws 200 people with known true skills (correlated as in NCPT), plays ten sessions each through the scoring and selection code, and checks the profile against the truth. Table 2 summarises the eleven experiments; figures are in the repository.

Question	Result	Target
Recovery of true skill (correlation), after 1 / 3 / 10 sessions	0.773 / **0.820** / 0.905	> 0.8 at 3
80% ranges containing the true skill	**79.9%**	75–85%
Achieved success in Balanced mode	77.7%	$80 \pm 5\%$
Worst core-skill σ after the warm-up	0.65	< 0.8
Bad-data detection, precision / recall	1.00 / 1.00	> 0.9 / > 0.8
RMSE after 10 sessions: usual / long gaps / 50–150 ms lag	0.449 / 0.479 / 0.535	reported
ACS rank stability under weight shifts (Spearman)	0.997	> 0.9
Coach faithfulness, final replies (local 4B model)	4/4	100%
Forecast coverage on held-out real players	79.7%	80%
Bandit gain over random games (95% interval)	+0.12 to +0.24	reported
Sessions completed with all models down / Qdrant down / both	18/18 each	100%

Table 2: Evaluation (`make eval`, seed 2026).

Generalisation and robustness. The models that touch real people were evaluated on held-out real users from public data (Lumosity, OULAD), not on the people they were trained on. Experiments 1–5 also run through the full agent graph (`make sim-graph`), and the system was tested with sessions weeks apart, device lag, every model failing and the memory store unreachable. The software is covered by 265 backend tests, 84 frontend unit tests and 14 end-to-end suites in a real browser, run in CI.

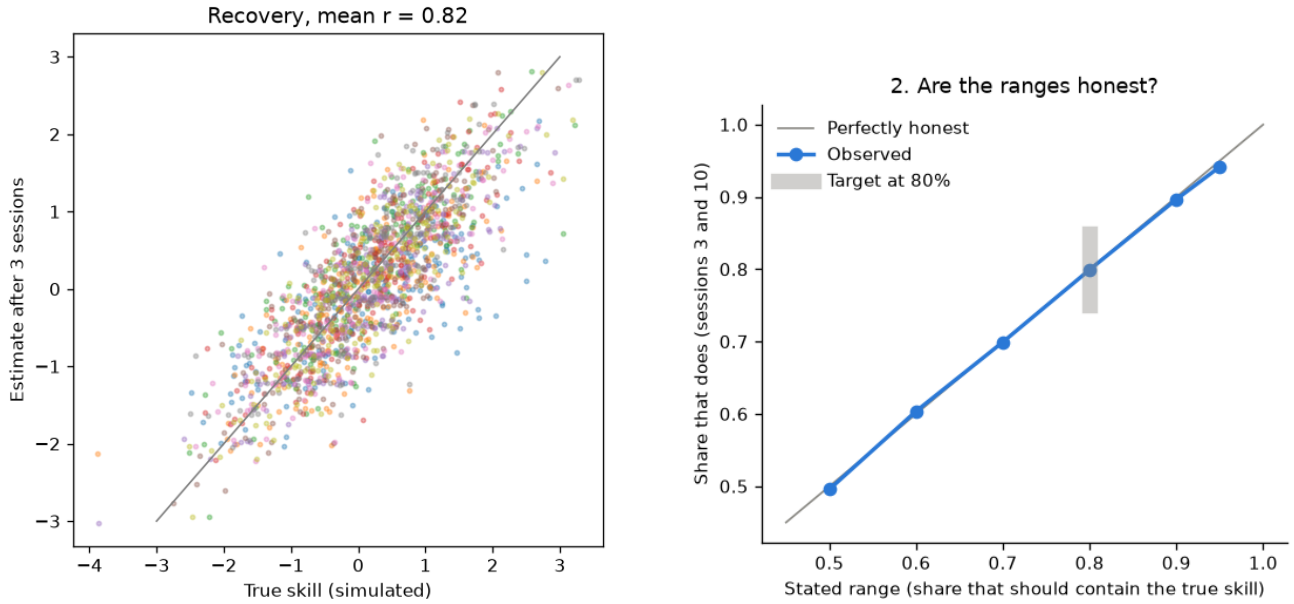


Figure 5: Left: recovery of true skill by session. Right: coverage of the 80% ranges.

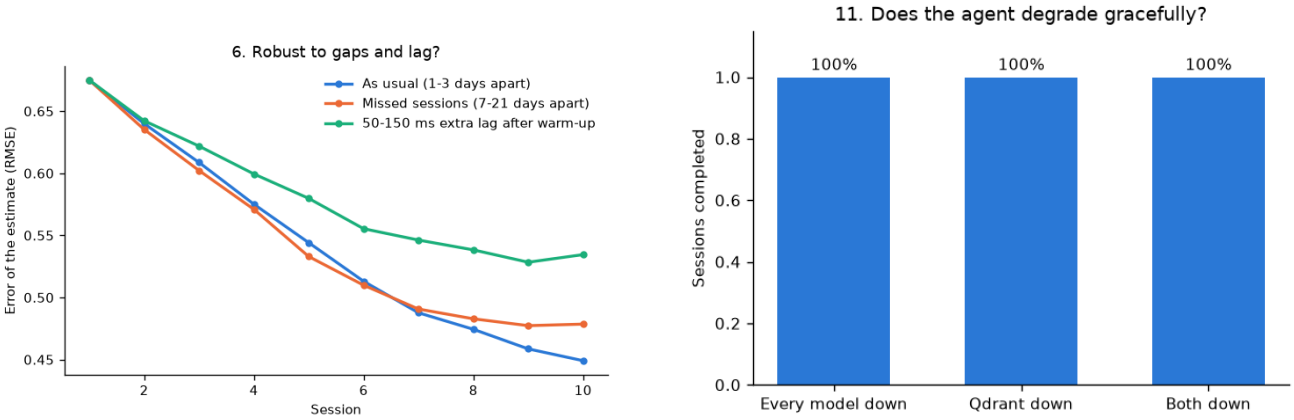


Figure 6: Robustness. Left: error after long gaps and with device lag. Right: sessions completed through the real agent with models, memory, or both unavailable.

9 Ethics, safety and data

Seven consent switches (core data, cloud AI, microphone, camera, voice tone, planted-mistake games, research export) are logged as events with the notice version; nothing is stored before the first-visit screens finish, and the app is for adults (18+). Camera and voice-tone cues are computed on the device, sent as one coarse number each, used only to suggest a break, and have no code path to the profile; no decision rests on face or voice alone. Users can read and forget any memory line, export everything, or delete everything and receive a receipt with the counts removed; a daily retention job removes old traces, checkpoints and events. Cloud AI receives only de-identified summaries. A banned-word list (diagnostic and clinical terms) is enforced in CI and in every reply, and a red-team suite checks requests for diagnoses. User API keys never appear in state, logs or exports.

10 Limitations and next steps

Validity rests on established paradigms and on the simulator, not yet on a study with real Lodestar users; percentiles use simulated norms until a linking study puts our scale against NCPT; the engagement model transfers from online courses to games; experimental skills (rhythm, creativity, accuracy awareness) are labelled as such. Next: a consented pilot with 5–10 people (usability, whether "why" cards are understood, labels for the frustration cues), a linking study for norms, and more languages.

References

Klinkenberg, Straatemeier & van der Maas (2011), Computer adaptive practice of Maths ability using a new item response model for on the fly ability and difficulty estimation. *Computers & Education*. Jaffe et al. (2022), NCPT, *Scientific Data*. Steyvers & Schafer (2020), *Nature Human Behaviour*. Kuzilek, Hlosta & Zdrahal (2017), OULAD, *Scientific Data*. Buçinca, Malaya & Gajos (2021), To trust or to think, *CSCW*. Vovk et al. (2015), Venn–Abers predictors.